



Saracoff Sentinel/Team Tijuana

Great Advances—

October 2008

Our hearts are stirred with the life and death heroics at Campo de Fe (the home for sick and wounded street people) where they are doing their best to save a street person with a bullet in his head. Humberto has a breathing tube in his throat and a feeding tube in his stomach. Others had given him up for dead, but not Felix. Felix, his new constant companion, knows what he is dealing with. Felix showed us his own scars where a knife was stabbed through his throat. Felix also had lived via tracheotomy and stomach tubes. God saved his life and uniquely equipped him to serve Humberto. You could say this story portrays the Christian life in a nutshell.



The first half of the youth center at Carretas is built and we are encouraged by partnerships with a local church and business to finish that building and help children get an education. This is a continuation of the project which has seen groups as far away as Canada working on the playground and others getting a shed built on the playground level. We still do not have a road to the top of the hill. Everything must be carried up, there's no electricity or running water, but young minds are not limited.

Our hearts are filled with joy as we see Josefina expanding her donut business at El Camino (her home for abandoned and abused women with children) The ladies make donuts and sell them on the streets to help finance the center. Part of our ministry is to make small business loans to the poor so they can become self-sufficient. Pray that God will bless their work.

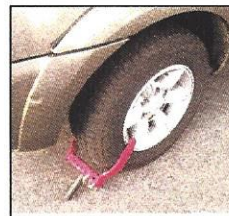
Another encouragement are the groups that come down once a month to make bountiful breakfasts for the Refugio for the Elderly and the children at Camino Vivo and Carretas. Food is necessary for the body, but interaction between people feeds the soul and is even more important.



We are pleased to see the new Casa Hogar opened for the handicapped younger women who had to be moved from the Refugio for the Ancianos because they were too young. Now these six women have a pleasant house in a tranquil neighborhood, with Pastor Salazar's wife Francisca looking after them and Salazar helping. The needs are many: repair the roof, fix a broken window, build ramps for wheelchairs to access the patio, replace missing bricks in the wall, plant flowers, find a vehicle to take them to church and a small car for Salazar to get to work and haul donations, and pay the monthly rent and utilities (less than \$300). But God is providing (the house belongs to a resident of the Refugio who can no longer live alone) and already they are sharing God's love with neighbors.

Esperanza Drug Rehab in Tijuana has been able to move their Zona Norte Rescue Mission to a better building and also continue a Good News Club there for children whose mothers are often prostitutes or street people. Kathy and 2 friends go weekly to Esperanza Women's Center to sing and pray. Gabriela came for rehab a month ago and her life has been transformed by Jesus. Her husband, in prison in the US, also met the Lord recently and they look forward to starting a new life together in Christ. On their main campus, Esperanza hopes to expand their vocational program into small businesses, so they can become more self-sufficient.

They have submitted a plan to produce the "Tijuana Boot," a security lock that goes on a car's tire. If they can be financed for the equipment, they can train the men to weld and produce these tire locks which will provide money needed for food and basic necessities at the center. On the humorous side—many of the rehab men used to be car thieves before they accepted the Lord so they can give the locks a thorough test to be sure they work. They say no one can beat their quality control department!



The Tijuana Boot

Some Danger—This is a touchy subject. We still feel it is safe for groups to come with us to the areas of Tijuana where we work, but anyone with a newspaper, TV or the internet knows that there is a lot of violence and kidnapping going on in Mexico right now. One step we have taken is to move our office where we meet with Team Tijuana leaders out of a nicer residential area. We find that the closer we stay around the poor and needy, the safer we are. It has been over 15 years since Greg's life was threatened by a drug gang so either things are more civilized now in these poor areas, or he has not been taking all the risks he should be taking!

Great Challenges—Greg's energy has been focused on the new project we have of making small business loans to the poor or to the ministries that help the needy. As these financial times teach us—giving income fluctuates. Often the ability of those to give to the needy is less when the need is greatest. The effect? the poor keep on needing and needing so the givers have to keep giving and giving and eventually this stresses out the givers—especially in hard economic times like now. Setting the needy up to be self-sufficient is, of course, the key. You read about some ministries we have already helped be self-sufficient. The new projects on the table are: a water filtration business alongside a laundry (to recycle the clean discharge water wasted in most water businesses), an auto repair shop (to save us from all the cars in TJ running around without good brakes), a self-supporting clinic, and a self-supporting dental clinic to serve the middle class (and with the profits treat the poor via mobile dental clinic). Our board is evaluating each one of these business plans. Do any of these interest you? Do you have technical experience you can share? Old equipment you could donate—printing equipment, commercial deep fryers, vehicles, etc.? Anything that could be used to start a business—now's the time to step forward!

Great Satisfaction—Like Felix who has seen God work in the past, we press on, knowing that the Lord has a plan to give hope to the people in Tijuana. In these areas of great darkness God shines the light of His gospel. Some things do give us pause and sometimes we could be afraid but we remember that "*Courage is only fear that has said its prayers.*" We see great courage in our Mexican colleagues and a harvest from your faith and giving to this ministry. With your help, over 40 children got enrolled in school, received supplies and could afford their uniforms. How satisfying this is! We thank God for your participation in this work—those of you who come down and those who give and pray and pass the word on to others. And keep on praying!

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Did you know school uniforms cost well over \$100 in Mexico?



Chela's jello for Anna's 18th birthday